Tales of Etheria: Adora as Rapunzel

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/62379328.

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General Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F, F/M

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Original Child Character(s)

Additional Tags:
Fairytale crossover, Inspired by Tangled (2010), Bedtime Stories, Catra is a good mom, Adora is a Dork (She-Ra), Married Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Married Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Fluff and Angst, Happy Ending

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by AstrynSerene

Summary

The story really starts out with a beautiful, golden flower. Now, this wasn't just any old flower. This flower contained the magic of healing given to it from the sun and stars above. Unfortunately, this flower had been found by a nasty old woman, who abused its power to keep herself young and healthy for hundreds of years using a simple but special little song.

Now, the queen was heavily pregnant with her second daughter, and had grown very, very sick. The kingdom was desperate to find a cure to save both the queen and the unborn princess. They'd heard rumors about this magical flower, and while none had seen it themselves, they were running out of options."

"I've heard you use us in your little casts for these. Can I take a wild guess that Shadow Weaver is the nasty old woman? Because her using magic to stay young is so not surprising." Glimmer cut in, snorting at the playful glare her advisor shot at her.

"Yes, Sparkles. Now shut it, you're running the immersion."

OR

Catra retelling the story of Rapunzel with a little casting switch to entertain Finn and Glimmer and Bow's twin girls,

Estelle and Galaxy

Notes

I've only been working on this since 2023 HAHA-

Anyway, I love fairytales, and I loved the idea of making SPoP crossover with my favorites, then I had the idea to make them into bedtime stories that Catra tells the kids! It was too cute not to do, and I have several ideas for future entries to this little series, but please please feel free to leave suggestions in the comments!

I did take the liberty to change some of the story to give it some originality, as well as some things that I felt Catra would change because she has a toddler audience.

See the end of the work for more notes

"Finn, Galaxy, gh- Estelle!" Glimmer groaned, pushing down her annoyance at her failure to get the kids to settle in for bed.

"Having trouble, Sparkles?" Catra chuckled as she walked into the bedroom, having gotten herself some tea from the kitchen.

"Yes!" The queen groaned again, watching as the three little ones continued waging war on each other with pillows across the room, "Help?" She pleaded, looking towards the magicat, who chuckled.

"Alright my little army, let's continue this tomorrow okay? Unless you wanna miss a *special* bedtime story that is.."

Finn gasped, ducking away from the soft arsenal before diving into their bed. They laughed when they received odd looks from the twins, "Mommy tells the *best* stories. You *don't* wanna miss them!"

Sharing a glance, the sisters shrugged before hopping down and off of their beds and joining Finn, looking up as Catra took a seat

on the edge of the bed, "Whatcha gonna tell us about this time, mommy?"

Over the years, Catra and Adora both had been exposed to Rebellion children's stories that their friends had grown up with as opposed to the twisted ones from the Horde. Catra thought they were fine, but after having Finn and Glimmer having the twins, she'd started.. changing those stories around for everyone's entertainment, especially her kit's.

Glimmer herself had yet to be around for one of these apparently famous story times, and took a seat in the rocking chair to listen in.

"Well.. It's about a flower, a beautiful princess, a *very* handsome thief, and an ugly old witch that tries to disguise herself with a mask of false beauty."

"I *know* you aren't starting without us!" Adora interrupted, a pout on her face as she entered the room, cup of tea in hand and Bow at her side, two cups in his hands.

"I was just introducing the concept, princess. Calm down."

Adora sipped on her tea with a huff, sitting next to Catra after adjusting her nightgown and resting her head on her wife's shoulder, "You may continue."

Bow had taken a seat on the window seat near his wife, handing her her own cup of tea before sipping his own. He'd heard snippets of Catra's bedtime tales, but he was excited to really listen in for the first time. It was just *so cute!*

"Okay, baby," Catra chuckled, wrapping her free arm around her before looking back to the kids, "So, like I was saying..

The story really starts out with a beautiful, golden flower. Now, this wasn't just any old flower. This flower contained the magic of healing given to it from the sun and stars above. Unfortunately, this flower had been found by a nasty old woman, who abused its power to keep herself young and healthy for hundreds of years using a simple but special little song.

Now, the queen was heavily pregnant with her second daughter, and had grown very, very sick. The kingdom was desperate to find a cure to save both the queen and the unborn princess. They'd heard rumors about this magical flower, and while none had seen it themselves, they were running out of options."

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"Yes, Sparkles. Now shut it, you're running the immersion."

"Fine, fine.." The queen took a drink of her tea, using her cup to hide her smile.

"Anyway," Catra cleared her throat to continue, "The king sent out various search parties all over Brightmoon, determined to find the-
"

"-the stowy takes place here?!" Galaxy, the younger of the twins gasped, eyes widening.

Catra smiled warmly, "Sure does, Gal."

Galaxy's eyes literally sparkled as she clung to her sister, "That's so cool!"

Adora couldn't help but giggle to herself, "Did they find the flower?" She asked to give her wife a prompt to continue.

Catra offered a grateful smile and a kiss to Adora's forehead, "It took nearly three days, but yes, they found the magical flower one night, and after carefully uprooting it, rushed it back to the palace to make a special tea for the queen..

Not long after, a beautiful princess was born, but unlike their first born, she had platinum blonde hair that had already grown a miraculous length. A little hint, we're gonna call her Adora."

Adora gasped, her eyes widening, "Awe..!" She giggled, curling up more against her wife. Her teacup had already been placed on the nightstand, long forgotten. Catra trilled, giving her a little squeeze.

"To celebrate the princess' birth, the kingdom celebrated by launching flying lanterns into the sky. Now, if you kits remember the witch from before, well she wasn't exactly happy to find out what happened to her magic flower. So as revenge, the night the princess was born, she snuck into the castle, using the same chant and discovering that Adora's hair held the same magical powers as the flower did. However, when she tried to cut a strand off, the platinum blonde faded to a more natural blonde. In the spur of the moment, she then grabbed the infant, fled the palace and just like that, she was gone.

The kingdom searched and searched but they couldn't find the princess."

"How come they couldn't find her, mommy?" Finn asked, tilting their head as their little tail swayed in fascination.

"Well, deep inside the Whispering Woods, Shadow Weaver had locked Adora away in a hidden tower, raising her as her own so she was free to use her magic hair."

"Sounds like her." Glimmer rolled her eyes, earning a small laugh from Bow and Adora.

"And mama got trapped forever?"

"Not forever," Catra snorted, "But for eighteen long years, Adora grew up locked in that tower. Weaver could only hide so much of the world though. As a way to preserve her memory, and to keep the search alive, her sister, Glimmer decided that each year on her birthday they would continue to send flying lanterns in the sky, hoping that one day, the lost princess would return."

⚔

Over the years, Adora had developed a weekly routine that she always did her best to follow to the letter before doing anything else. Sometimes it changed, but the average week tended to

remain the same. Mondays she spent cleaning the tower top to bottom, then her afternoons were free to read one of the thirteen books she had available to her. She usually only had a few hours to read before she had to prepare dinner for her and her mother anyway.

Tuesdays were her free day, which she always spent painting one of the walls of the tower. There weren't many that had free space left, eighteen years of work would do that to a place, but she somehow always managed to find more room. She always used the afternoon and the following Wednesday morning to work on brushing her hair. She had seventy feet of it after all.

~

" *Seventy* feet?!" Adora, Finn, and the twins all gasped in unison.

"I'm retelling Rapunzel guys, yes." Catra laughed.

"I would *die* if I had that much hair." Adora shivered, clinging to Catra. She'd made herself more comfortable cuddled up to her wife.

"Well, it's a story. Now shush." The magicat laughed, caressing Adora's hair as she continued.

⚔

Thursdays she focused on things to improve the tower. Candle making, pottery, whittling, anything she could make that she could use to decorate her home with. If she was lucky, her mother would occasionally bring her home new supplies like clay or wax.

Fridays and Saturdays were the only days her mother always stayed home, so she always spent those with her. Finally, she spent Sundays washing her hair if her mother hadn't helped the day before, and then the rest of the day painting or reading, anything to help her relax for the day.

Today, Friday, was one of the rare days she cleaned her hair early.

"Mother?" She called, currently struggling with her massive pile of hair soaking in the tub.

"Is everything alright?" Shadow Weaver asked, peaking through the curtain to the bathroom, where she found Adora sitting on a stool, the middle section of her hair piled in the tub, "Do you need help?"

"Please… I always forget how heavy this can get.."

"Of course," Weaver chuckled, approaching the tub and beginning to assist in washing her hair, "You could have just asked me before you started."

"I know, I just- wanted to try and..do it myself this time.."

Shaking her head with a smile, Shadow Weaver helped Adora through the grueling process. It took three hours, but once they finished, carefully moved into the main room of the tower to relax and have lunch.

While they ate, however, a lot was going through Adora's mind, "So, uhm…mother..?"

"Yes, flower?"

"Well, so- you know tomorrow is kind of a big day and I just.. I wanted to ask if maybe.." Setting her bowl aside, Adora took a deep breath and looked up at her mother, "I… I was hoping that maybe.. I wanna see the floating lights!"

Stopping, Weaver looked up, raising an eyebrow, “The- what?”

“The lights! You know the ones that come by every year- coincidentally on my birthday which happens to be tomorrow-”

“Okay okay, Adora please, slow down. You know how I feel about that, nobody can understand a word you say when you talk so fast.”

“Sorry! I just… you know, I’m turning eighteen so.. I thought that maybe I could… that you could take me to see the floating lights? You know- outside?”

“Adora, we’ve talked about this.”

“I know! I just figured since I’m older maybe we could…”

The blonde trailed off as her mother stood and approached, cupping her cheek and gently brushing a strand of hair behind her ear, “You know as well as I do how dangerous the world is, how many people would take advantage of your power. We cannot risk you leaving this tower, ever.”

“But- if we went together-”

“Adora, we are done talking about this.”

“I just thought-”

“ *Adora.* The answer is no. We’ve been over this.”

Before she could retaliate, Adora tensed when the soft hold on her cheek hardened, making her wince, “Yes, mother…”

Smiling, Weaver moved her hand from her cheek to lightly pat her on the head, “Good. Now, with that nonsense taken care of, do you have anything actually feasible you’d like for your birthday?”

With her mood soured, Adora sighed, blinking a few times before smiling softly, “I’ll think about it over the afternoon while you’re out?”

Nodding, Weaver took her empty plate to the sink, “Of course. I should only be gone a few hours, I just need to gather some things for dinner.”

“Okay.”

Adora cleaned and put away their plates while her mother got ready, before meeting her at the window, “I love you..”

“I love you too, flower. I’ll see you in a bit, okay?” Weaver hummed as she sat on the window sill, letting Adora loop her hair over the hook above the window before taking hold and starting her decent, “While I’m gone, see to it the bathroom gets cleaned up will you? It’s always a mess after you wash your hair!”

“Oh..! Uh- of course, mother!” Adora waved, waiting for Weaver to reach the ground and start walking off before letting her hair come off the hook. She wasn’t sure how long she stared at the sky before heading inside, but time didn’t matter to her. It was endless her tower after all.

⚔

“I will *never* be able to imagine Shadow Weaver saying she loves anyone. Adora would probably be the closest though.” Glimmer snorted, setting her teacup on the table by the window seat she and Bow had cuddled up in.

Catra glanced at Adora when she felt her shiver, “No thank you.” The blonde huffed, making her wife laugh.

“Shadow Weaver sounds bad.” Galaxy commented, face scrunching up in disgust.

“That, she *very* much was- is.” Catra cleared her throat.

“I assume we’re about to meet the elusive handsome thief?” Adora smiled, sliding her hand up to cup her partner’s cheek, her expression shifting to almost a smirk.

Blushing, Catra placed her hand over Adora’s, squeezing it lightly, “You would like that wouldn’t you?” She giggled, “Yes, we are. Along with a few of her friends.”

⚔

The sound of hoof steps and footfall echoed behind the trio as they raced through the Whispering Woods, weaving through trees, branches, and bushes, “Think they’re getting tired yet?!” Catra cackled as she leapt into a low hanging tree branch, starting to dart across the branches above her friends.

“Doubt it! Based on our past chases with the castle guard we will have to continue to outrun them for at least twenty more minutes!” Entrapta exclaimed.

“Ha! That’s nothing!” The brunette smirked.

“Ha- yeah! Yeah, I could run from them all- all day!” Scorpia huffed, clearly struggling to keep up, “Have you guys gotten faster?”

“It’s alright, Scorp! We’ll lose ‘em soon!” Catra scanned the area, smirking when she saw what she was looking for, “Go right!” She yelled, spotting a tunnel entrance covered by vines. She leapt down after them, only for an arrow to fly past her face, slamming into a nearby tree as a net burst out of the arrow and wrapped around the tree trunk. She shrieked, looking back to see the captain of the guard gaining quick proximity on his horse. She quickly turned and raced the other direction. It was a common tactic the trio used to force the guards to split up. Catra was best to venture on her own; her ability to track people through scent made her the safest option.

Dropping to all fours, she took off down the opposite pathway, her ear twitching and a smirk forming as she heard the captain split off to chase her, “Keep trying, Captain Arrows! You might catch me one day!” She eyed a nearby branch, “It won’t be today though!” She cackled, leaping into the trees once again.

~

“Captain Arrows?” Adora snickered, unable to help herself.

“Hey, I can’t exactly use myself here, so Bow can have my job for this.”

“Daddy captain!” Estelle laughed, making Bow smile.

Laughing, Catra shifted to get more comfortable. She had moved to lay against the headboard of Finn's bed. Adora had quickly cuddled up on her left, head on her shoulder. Finn had curled up on her legs, listening with a swaying tail, and the twins were snuggled together on Catra's right, "I would have used Sparkles, but I can't very well give her two roles either."

Smiling, Glimmer stretched as she pulled a blanket over herself and her husband, "Adora and I act like sisters anyway, so it's not that much of a stretch."

"Daddy wouldn't have missed though!" Galaxy giggled, "Daddy never ever ever misses!"

Blushing lightly, Bow said nothing, simply leaning back and holding Glimmer closer.

"Speaking from experience, Gal, I know," Catra chuckled, ruffling the princess' hair, "But for story purposes, let's just say he had a bad day."

"Okay..!" Galaxy giggled.

~

Dancing across the branches to escape the guards was practically a norm for Catra. It made it more difficult to be spotted, gave her a visual advantage of the surrounding area and possible escape routes, and it was way more fun!

She heard a few more arrows fly, more nets following, but none of them got even close to her, only serving to inflate her ego and confidence. She scanned the area below, spotting exactly what she needed to. After scaling a few more trees, she made her leap down into some brush, before racing into a vine-covered cavern on all fours to remain out of sight. She pressed herself to the wall, ear twitching again as she listened, pleased when she heard hoof steps race past her and slowly fade as they hurried down the path.

Taking a deep breath, she looked around, realizing that the cavern seemed to be more of… a tunnel? Huh. Slowly, after checking on the crown tucked away in her satchel, she made her way deeper into the tunnel, soon coming upon another curtain of vines. Carefully, she pushed them aside, and stepped out to reveal a beautiful hidden corner of the Whispering Woods. She gasped, eyes widening as she took in the scene. A waterfall flowed down into a crystal clear pond. Landscape and flowers surrounded the water, trees and bushes giving the area life. In the center of it all stood a tall tower, the only entrance a single window at the very top of the structure, "Wow…" She breathed, taking a few steps closer, tilting her head to look at the top.

The place *looked* abandoned yet well preserved from the outside, but she wasn't stupid. There could easily be someone living, or trapped, inside. Still, it was an ideal place to hide out until she knew the guards were no longer looking for her and she could return to her friends. So, she unsheathed her claws to their fullest

extent before stepping up to the wall, and starting to climb the stones. Luckily, they were uneven, which made the ascent easier. Even if they had been smooth though, she still could have made it, it would have just taken longer.

When she reached the top, she pushed the window shutter open and toppled inside. She managed to land on her feet, barely. She glanced around. A candle lit chandelier was in the middle of the room, hanging from the rafters, there were a few potted plants here and there, clearly well taken care of. Paintings covered the walls; she couldn't find a single inch of it that didn't have some sort of shape or picture painted on. She tilted her head slightly, taking a few steps further into the tower, "Huh…" Someone definitely lived here, but the question was, who-

Her ear flicked back slightly as she heard steps behind her, but before she could turn around, a frying pan collided with her head hard enough to knock her unconscious.

⚔

Catra blushed heavily as her crowd giggled and laughed.

"Ooh I forgot about the frying pan. That's amazing. Adora absolutely *would* use one as a weapon too." Glimmer snickered, the blonde rolling her eyes fondly, "You know, I think I actually remember a time she accidentally turned her sword into one!"

“Hey! Clearly it *can* work!”

“Ugh, yeah yeah, laugh it up.” The brunette smiled, purring quietly as she rubbed Finn’s back.

“Awe, it’s okay, love.” Adora smiled, brushing a strand of hair out of Catra’s face, “I would never hit you with a frying pan.”

“You better not!” The brunette laughed, leaning over to kiss her forehead before leaning back, “Everyone got it out of their system now?”

Taking a deep breath, Finn nodded, “Yes mommy, you can keep goings now.”

“Thank you, little one.” Catra smiled.

⚔

Adora squeaked as she dipped behind the body length mirror in the corner. Slowly, she peaked her head out at the person she’d laid out in the middle of the room. They didn’t… look like any of the monsters her mother had described over the years. In fact, they were smaller than she was! Slowly, she stepped out from behind the mirror, taking careful steps towards the magicat. She adjusted her skirts as she crouched down next to her, using the

handle of the frying pan to move the hair out of the woman's face. She gasped softly- she was beautiful! Biting her lip, she then used the handle to move her lip. She had fangs, like her mother said people had, but they didn't look threatening in any way. She hummed, pulling her frying pan to her chest. She winced when a light hit her eyes, and looked down at the satchel. She looked back at the girl's face momentarily to make sure she wouldn't wake up, before slowly reaching forward and opening the bag, and taking out the shiny object inside.

It was beautiful. Three jewels were the centerpiece, see through, and surrounded by tiny pearls. The piece had diamonds lining the gold, accented with red and blue jewels, circling around, kind of like a necklace or bracelet, but it seemed to be too big to be either of those things. She rose back to her feet, turning towards the mirror. She shifted her glance between the object and the mirror, tilting her head as she tried to figure out where to place it. Wrist? No. Neck? Definitely not. Head? Slowly, she brought it up and turned it around, carefully placing it on her head. It was a perfect fit, like it was always meant to be there. She couldn't help but stare at her reflection. What was this thing? Was it meant for her? Why-

"Adora..!"

Gasping, the blonde looked up towards her window.

"Let down your hair!"

Eyes widening, she quickly took the jewelry off and dropped it and the satchel into a nearby pot, before grabbing the magicat and lifting her off the floor, “Just a moment, mother!”

“I’ve got a big surprise!”

“Uh.. I do too!”

“I bet my surprise is bigger!”

“I seriously doubt it…” She muttered, opening her wardrobe and practically shoving her inside and shutting the door. After a deep breath, she rushed over to the window and looped her hair around the hook before tossing the rest down the side of the tower. She help lift her mother to the window sill with ease, the older woman sitting on the ledge and smiling at her.

“I brought back parsnips to make hazelnut soup for dinner. I know it’s your favorite, surprise!”

Smiling, Adora helped her inside, taking her cloak and hanging it up for her, “That’s great, mother. Thank you!”

“Oh you know how I hate leaving you after a fight, especially when they had no reason to happen in the first place.” Weaver sighed, setting her basket on the counter.

“Ha, ha- yeah… Uhm, so- mother about before I-”

“-And you know I did absolutely nothing wrong and I’m only doing everything I can to protect you.”

“Yes… Well- mother, I was just thinking and you- you think I’m not strong enough to handle myself out there.”

Weaver laughed, “Oh, flower I *know* you’re not strong enough to handle yourself out there.”

“But if you just listen…” Adora tried, inching towards the wardrobe.

“Adora, we are *done* discussing this.”

“ *Trust* me, I know what I’m doing-”

“-Adora-”

“-Just please give me a chance to-”

"-Enough with the lights Adora! You are NOT leaving this tower! EVER!"

Flinching, Adora slowly removed her hand from the wardrobe door, eyes glossing over as she stared at her mother.

"Ugh, great!" Weaver exclaimed, dramatically sitting in a nearby chair, "Now I'm the bad guy!"

Swallowing the lump in her throat, the teen lightly hugged herself, willing her tears to not fall, "…All I was gonna say is that- I know what I want for my birthday now." She spoke softly, as quietly as she could without her mother scolding her as she stepped in front of the wardrobe.

"And *what* is *that? "*

"Uhm… new paints? The.. The ones from the Salineian shells you once brought me?"

"Well *that* is a very long trip you know. Almost three day's time."

"I just… thought it would be a better idea than the..s..stars.."

Sighing, Weaver put on a smile as she got back to her feet, her tone having completely shifted as she wrapped her daughter in a hug, “You sure you’ll be alright on your own?”

“I know I’m safe as long as I’m here…”

“I love you very much, flower.”

“I love you more.”

“I love you most.”

⚔

“Weaver is so meanie!” Galaxy huffed, crossing her arms and blowing a raspberry.

“Yeah, she needs to let mama out!” Finn agreed.

“Don’t worry, kittens, we’ll get there.” Catra purred, tail wrapping around the twins while she pulled Finn closer to her chest.

“We have to let the lesbian out of the closet first.” Bow snorted, getting a laugh out of Glimmer and Adora, while Catra bit back her laughter with a scoff.

“You are such a dad.”

“Just like his own with humor.” Glimmer giggled, kissing his cheek.

“What happens after the witch leaves?” Estelle asked softly, eyes sparkling with interest as she looked up at her aunt.

“Well, as soon as Weaver was gone, Adora quickly returned her attention to her wardrobe…”

⚔

The moment her mother was out of sight, Adora ran back and grabbed her frying pan, aiming it at the closet doors as she slowly approached. Before she could get there though, the doors were pushed open as the brunette stumbled out. She gasped and dodged as Adora tried to swing the pan at her again, “Please don’t give me a second migraine! I’m not going to hurt you!” She claimed, stepping back and holding her hands up against her chest.

Narrowing her eyes, Adora kept the weapon aimed at the intruder, “Who are you, and how did you find me?”

Now that she was looking at the blonde, it was hard to ignore just how breathtakingly *beautiful* she was. Catra look a deep breath, “My name is Catra. I wasn’t like- hunting you, I found your tower on accident. I was- exploring the woods and stumbled upon a cavern that turned out to be a tunnel to here. I was curious, that’s all. It’s not often you find intact architecture out here.”

“Hm…” Adora paused, before realizing she didn’t know how long this- Catra, had been awake, “How much did you hear..?”

“Oh you mean your wicked witch of a mother? Yeah, I heard all that. Why is she so hellbent on keeping you up here?” Slowly, she glanced around the tower and finally noticed just how much hair she had, “I’m guessing it has something to do with your ridiculously long hair?”

Tensing, Adora stepped back, pushing some hair on the floor behind her with her leg, “You don’t need to know about my hair. Just don’t touch it, and if you try to cut it, I will use this.” She tried to look and sound threatening as she kept the frying pan aimed at the magicat, but with all the guards she had encountered over the years, Catra just found the attempt a little pitiful. Cute though.

“Okayyy… Well, what- wait,” Her eyes widened when she realized the crown was no longer in her bag, “Where’s the crown?”

“Crown?” Adora asked, arching an eyebrow.

“The- the thing that was in my satchel. Where did you put it?”

“Oh! I…” Adora looked towards the fireplace, where her painting of the lanterns sat above it, and she smiled. Mother would be gone for three days… “I’ve hidden it! But- I’ll give it back to you if you do something for me.”

Catra crossed her arms, “What?”

“I need a guide, someone who can take me to see the floating lights,” She pointed to her painting, “and return me home safely.”

That was it? Catra’s expression softened, “Lights? You mean the lantern thing they do for the princess?”

“Lanterns…” Adora breathed, “I knew they weren’t just stars..!”

“Yeah no, it’s a thing they do every year. That’s all you want to see?”

“Yes!” The blonde perked up, smiling again, “They appear every year on my birthday but I’ve only been able to see them from my window. I want to see them up close.”

“Sure, I can take you.” Catra smiled. Just hearing the nasty way her ‘mother’ had spoken to Adora was more than enough of a reason alone. The poor girl had clearly been locked away her entire life. Who does that?

“Wait- *really?”* Adora smiled, eyes lighting up.

“Yeah, you clearly need a field trip.”

Giggling, Adora lunged forward and wrapped her arms around Catra without thinking, “Thank you thank you thank you!”

“Ghm! Uh- you’re welcome?”

Realizing what she had done, Adora quickly backed off, dusting her dress off as her face turned red, “Sorry! Wait- Are we leaving now?”

“If you’re ready, princess.” Catra smirked, “We have quite a bit of ground to cover.”

Nodding, Adora slowly followed Catra to the window. For her part, the magicat simply unsheathed her claws and started to quickly descend the tower. Adora started towards the window, before pausing. She bit her lip, glancing back towards the pot. She sighed, running over and lifting the crown out of it. She then grabbed her own satchel from a nearby table, which was a gray fabric as opposed to the brown leather of her new- friend's? Once she put the crown as well as her frying pan into the bag, she slipped it onto her shoulder and finally made her way to the window, where she carefully looped her hair over the hook, watching as her guide swiftly made her way to the ground.

"You coming?!" Catra called, looking up once she was on the ground.

Nodding, Adora gripped her hair, taking a deep breath as she took another step forward, before closing her eyes and making the leap out of her tower. She couldn't help but laugh as she gripped her hair, free falling down the side of her tower stopping a few inches from the ground, eyes widening as she stared at the field of grass surrounding her. She stared at the ground in wonder, very slowly reaching her foot out to press against the landscape. She tilted her head at the soft feeling, having expected it to be sharp or spiky.

"You alright, princess?" Catra asked, raising an eyebrow at the odd behavior.

"It just- wow…" Adora giggled, finally standing fully and letting her hair fall to the ground around her, "This is so cool!"

The brunette blinked, “Well- come on. I need to make sure my friends are okay and we have a bit of ground to cover to get to the lanterns.”

“Okay..!” Adora smiled, a little nervous at the thought of more people, “I guess- lead the way!”

Nodding, Catra made her way back to the tunnel, holding the vines back for the blonde as she slowly made her way through, her eyes widening as she stepped out the other side, getting her first real view of the world for the first time in her life. Her pupils dilated as she looked around. The path, the trees, the flowers and bushes! It was all so beautiful! She squeaked as a bunny hopped out of a bush and raced across the dirt path, making her jump back behind her guide, “What is that?!”

“Relax. It’s a bunny. Totally harmless.”

Adora nodded with a blush, gripping onto her frying pan that she’d aimed at the poor creature, “Sorry…”

“It’s fine.” Catra laughed, gesturing them forward, “So you’ve- really never left that tower huh?”

Shaking her head, Adora bit her lip as she looked around, her brain still trying to process what she had done. If her mother ever found out, she would never forgive her for the betrayal! The thought of her mother being angry with her made her tense, but

she did her best to push it to the back of her mind. She had already taken the leap, and she wouldn't go back now. She was going to see those lanterns, no matter what.

⚔

"I can't imagine having that much hair still." Adora huffed, "What I have now is sometimes barely manageable!"

"You're so dramatic, princess." Catra teased, her hand absentmindedly running her fingers through her wife's hair, "Your hair is beautiful."

Blushing, Adora curled up a little more, resting her head on Catra's chest, giggling when Finn kissed her cheek, "Thank you sweetheart."

"I love you, mama!"

"I love you too, little one." Adora gently cupped her child's cheek for a moment, kissing their forehead.

"You know, it makes sense that Adora is Rapunzel now. Only she would take so long to realize her birthday matches the mystery princess." Glimmer smirked, laughing when Adora glared playfully at her.

“Hey!”

“I’m just saying, you’re smart, but you’re also kinda dense sometimes.”

Adora huffed, crossing her arms. Catra laughed, rubbing her wife’s back, “It’s okay. It’s all part of the story.”

Though she pouted, Adora finally settled back against her partner, holding Finn in her lap as Catra continued the story.

⚔

Adora couldn’t keep her gaze in one place more than a few seconds as she followed Catra down the dirt pathway. Everything was new and exciting and she didn’t want to miss a second of anything!

The brunette couldn’t help but smile whenever she glanced Adora’s way. Her excitement and pure joy around every little thing was so endearing.

“Wildcat!!”

“Catra!?”

Adora immediately tensed at the new voices, looking to her guide, who returned a warm smile, “Don’t worry, those are my two friends I was talking about. They’re both… enthusiastic, but safe. I think you’ll like them.”

Nodding, the blonde took a deep breath, managing not to flinch when two people suddenly hurried through the brush, one had muscular arms and the other had long hair like she did. It wasn’t nearly as long as Adora’s, and it was purple, but it still touched the ground and almost seemed to be- sentient?

“Thank goodness you’re alright Wildcat! When you didn’t show up at our meeting spot we were worried you’d gotten captured by the guards!”

“Relax, Scorpia. Those guards are always three steps behind me.” Catra smirked, a fang poking past her lip, “I just, ran into Blondie over here.” She motioned to Adora, who gave an awkward wave, a small yelp escaping when the one with purple hair started circling her, like she was examining her. She was at least mindful not to step on Adora’s hair, though she probably has similar experiences in that field.

“Your hair is abnormally long, even by my standards. I definitely haven’t seen you around before. Do you live in the woods? Somehow, you look familiar to me. Have we met before?”

“I- uhm..”

“Entrapta, relax. Give her some space. She’s- new to- things.” Catra tried to explain, glad when the latter finally took a few steps back and gave Adora a second to relax.

“Well, it’s lovely to meet you! Uhm..?”

“Oh! Uh- A-Adora. My name’s Adora.” Blushing heavily, the blonde gently took Scorpia’s offered pincer and shook it before taking a step towards her guide, “Catra is taking me to see the st- no, not stars. Lanterns.”

“Oh! The princess thing? Fun! We’ve never been in the kingdom when that’s happening.” Scorpia smiled, lightly pushing her bangs out of her face.

“For good reason! We are fugitives!” Entrapta added, wincing when Catra shoved her arm.

“ Entrapta..! ” The brunette muttered through closed teeth, glaring in her friend’s direction.

Adora decided not to question that. Surely whatever they were doing had to be for a good reason! Right?

"So, where *is* the crown?"

At that, Adora tensed, "I have it." She hastily replied before Catra could, "She's… taking me to see the lanterns in exchange for it…"

"Oh!" Scorpia looked surprised, but nodded. At least it was safe somewhere?

"Well, where exactly are we going for that? All things considered." Entrapta glanced towards Catra, who sighed, running her fingers through her hair.

"Right now, I'm just focused on us finding a safe camp for the night. We'll worry about the rest tomorrow."

Nodding, the group finally started to walk again, but it was barely five minutes before Entrapta started asking questions again.

"Do you just like growing your hair out or is there a reason you seem to have never cut it?"

Adora tensed, "Just- I just don't want to cut it."

She took Entrapta's silence as her answer being accepted. She was grateful when she quickly moved on from the topic, "So, is

the no shoes a personal choice too?”

“Huh?” Adora looked down, realizing Entrapta and Scorpia both had on similarly designed boots, Catra however.. “Catra isn’t wearing any.”

“That’s why I asked if it was a personal choice. It is for her, being a magicat and all, shoes aren’t the most comfortable for her.”

“Oh, well, I guess? I’ve just- never had a reason to wear any. I’ve… never left my tower before today.”

“Tower?” Scorpia raised an eyebrow.

“Mhm… it’s my home. I live there with my mother.”

“A very controlling and self-centered mother.” Catra held her hands up momentarily when Adora cast a soft glare her direction, “Oh come on! She is ! And she’s way too obsessed with you not leaving. Like, *suspiciously* obsessed.”

“She’s just… she’s just trying to protect me.”

“From what? Shears?”

“No..” Furrowing her eyebrows, Adora sighed, “It’s- it’s complicated. I don’t… I’m not gonna talk about it.”

Though she frowned, Catra nodded, “Understood. Still, you can’t blame me for finding the whole thing weird when I have zero context.”

“I know.. I just, sorry.”

Seeing how uncomfortable and how- almost at war she seemed with herself, Catra let it go for the time being. She couldn’t help but secretly hope that eventually she would learn more about the mysterious blonde and her clearly complicated life story.

⚔

“I really need to get your Entrapta impression on recording. I’d love to see her face listening to it.” Glimmer smirked, a small yelp escaping when Catra chucked a pillow at her face.

“I will end you if I ever see a trackerpad in here during one of these.” Catra glared, though there was only some seriousness behind it, “Story time is only for those who are here. No recordings.”

“Yeah! Special story times! You have to be there!” Finn declared, sitting up in Adora’s lap and crossing their arms.

“Yeah!” The twins added, giggling when Catra’s tail wrapped around them.

“Fineeeee, fine.” Glimmer sighed, but had a smile on her face.

“Oh oh! Auntie Catra!” Galaxy exclaimed, raising her hand and waving her hand, “What- what happens when they get to the campsite!”

“Right. Well, once they found the campsite, they had to set up for the night…”

⚔

“Alright I think that’s everything!” Scorpia smiled as she sat a second log on the other side of the small campfire Catra and Entrapta had built.

“Yup! We can officially take time to rest before the big adventure tomorrow.” Entrapta added with a bright smile before plopping down next to Scorpia on the log across from where Catra and Adora were sitting.

“Yeah… I could use it.” Catra huffed, wincing when she tried to lean back on her right hand.

“Is everything okay?” Adora asked, concerned when the brunette recoiled her hand against her chest.

“Yeah, I’m fine. Just, scraped my hand when I climbed down your tower.”

Guilt found it’s way to Adora’s chest, “May I see..?”

“I guess..?”

Slowly, Adora took Catra’s hand in her own, gently turning her palm up to examine the wound. It wasn’t too deep, and was probably more painful than it should be from her working on the camp without bandaging it. Biting her lip, Adora took a deep breath. It was a risk to reveal her secret to three people, but Catra was only injured because of her. It seemed only right to make it better, “Okay, I can fix this, but you have to promise, all of you, to not- freak out.”

“Why? Are you carrying secret bandages in your hair too?” Entrapta asked, a strand of her own hair sticking out, holding a few bandages, “You can use them if you need to!”

"Uhm…" Adora glanced to Catra, who just shrugged, before looking back with a soft smile, "Thank you, but, uh, there's no need." She slowly lifts a few strands of her hair and starts wrapping it gingerly around the injured hand.

"Uhm… Adora.. I don't see how putting me on a seventy foot leash is gonna do anything…" Catra tried to joke, wincing when Adora added too much pressure.

"Sorry…!" Biting her lip, the blonde shook her head, "And that's not… just, trust me. Please? This is gonna be- weird. Just don't- don't freak out…"

"Uh-huh…"

Taking a deep breath, and letting her eyes fall closed so she could concentrate, Adora started quietly singing.

Flower, gleam, and glow…

The moment Adora's hair started to glow, Scorpia and Catra froze, eyes widening as they watched the light flow from her roots and down the trail of hair until it reached Catra's hand. Entrapta immediately moved closer, inspecting the small spectacle over the magicat's shoulders.

Heal what has been hurt,

Change the Fates' design;

Save what has been lost, bring back what once was mine;

What once was mine…

Adora slowly opened her eyes, biting her lip when Entrapta slowly reached forward and pulled the strand loose, letting it fall away to reveal Catra's hand completely healed and void of any hint of a wound.

"I…" Catra stared at her hand, astonished by the sudden lack of a cut. There wasn't even a scar! Her pupils slowly dilated, her mind reeling in different directions to try and process how the magic healing just happened, "How- huh- what!? How-?!"

"Please don't freak out!" Adora exclaimed, holding her hands up defensively for a moment.

"Please explain everything on how that just happened, don't leave out a single detail, tell me everything !"

Adora took a moment to process each of the questions, gently nudging Entrapta to step back out of her face before taking a deep breath, "Okay- so… long story short, I was born with this gift

of healing. Mother says it came from the sun, that with that song, anything hurt I can heal. But… once I cut my hair, it fades to a less platinum blonde and loses its power.” She emphasized her point by pulling the hair away from her ear to reveal a short strand of blonde hair that was much duller than the rest, “A gift like this it- it has to be protected so… That’s why I never left and…”

“You never left that tower?” Catra asked. Adora nodded, glanced down at her hands resting in her lap. Slowly, the brunette reached over, placing her hand on top of Adora’s, “And… you’re still gonna go back?”

“No!” Adora snapped, before recoiling, biting her lip, “Yes..?” She groaned, “It’s complicated. I just… I’ve only been out here a few hours, but even just our walk to this campsite has been amazing! I’ve learned more in a few hours about the world than I have in a lifetime in my tower. I know mother wants to protect me, and I know things are dangerous but…”

“Well, a big help for you would honestly be by braiding your hair. It would keep it off the ground and you wouldn’t have as much risk of someone hurting it.” Scorpia suggested, bringing a small smile to Adora’s face as she looked up at her.

“Do you know how..?”

“I do, actually, though Catra is much better at it than me, and I do have sharp pincers… Maybe she could braid it for you!”

The look Adora gave Catra when she turned towards her made up the magicat's mind almost immediately. She sighed, feigning slightly annoyance, though a smile remained on her face, "Sure, why not? Turn around, princess. I'll have your hair fixed in a jiffy."

With a small giggle, Adora nodded and carefully shifted to face away from Catra, adjusting her skirt accordingly. She slowly relaxed as the brunette started setting up her hair in three long strands with Entrapta's assistance.

It took several hours, and by the time they finally finished the complicated braid, they had little time to admire it before they all fell asleep for the night, huddled somewhat close together around the campfire.

⚔

"Ooh, my favorite part is coming up!" Adora giggled, adjusting a half asleep Finn in her arms. Though, the kitten seemed to perk up a bit when their mother mentioned their favorite part was coming up.

"Yeah, the kingdom and lantern scenes would be your favorite. You're so cheesy." Catra teased, reaching over and brushing her wife's bangs out of her face before leaning in and gently kissing her cheek. Adora responded appropriately by sticking her tongue out and blowing a raspberry at her.

“Ooh, before we get there, I need more tea!” Glimmer decided, “Anyone else?” She took everyone’s nod of agreement and quickly gathered the teacups before teleporting down to the kitchen.

“Well, while we wait for Glimmer, does anyone have a favorite part yet?” Catra asked, the kids all lighting up at the opportunity.

“I love the part where mama jumped out of the tower with her hair and you climbed down with your claws mommy! Is your claws really that strong!?” Finn gasped, eyes sparkling with wonder.

“Yes, they are.” Catra had a proud smirk on her face.

“Will mine ever be that strong!?”

“Give it a few years, little one, but eventually they will be.” Catra smiled, nuzzling her kitten’s cheek.

Though they were momentarily disappointed, Finn was quickly absolved by the affection from their mommy. They giggled, tail wagging as they nodded, “Okay!”

“MY favorite part is the big chase at the start!” Estelle proudly stated.

“Me too! Me too!” Galaxy added, “’Specially when daddy fired his awows!” She demonstrated by pretending to fire arrows from an invisible bow, imitating the sound of shooting an arrow and bringing warm smiles to the adults in the room, especially Bow (who was absolutely not trying to hold back tears).

Glimmer finally teleported back into the room, a tray of tea in hand as well as cups of apple juice for the kids, “Drinks have arrived.” She chuckled, passing the cups and sippy cups out before settling back against Bow.

“Perfect timing, I was just getting ready to continue the story.” Catra hummed, wagging her tail as she took a sip of her tea, “So, the next morning, the sun has just peered over the trees surrounding the camp, when the group was woken up by an uninvited guest…”

⚔

Adora woke up to the sound of Catra yelping and hissing, quickly sitting up and turning her attention to Catra, who was being dragged by her leg across their campsite by… a horse?

“Whoa whoa whoa!” Adora rushed over before Scorpia or Entrapta could scramble a plan together, nudging herself between the two and forcing the horse to drop Catra, “Calm down, it’s okay! It’s okay…” The horse, an alicorn if Adora’s memory served her correctly, stared at her for a few minutes before slowly calming

down, though they continued to glare at Catra over the blonde's shoulder, "There you go, that's it!" Adora smiled, gently reaching forward and petting his muzzle, "Awe, you're such a good boy… Swiftwind." She giggled, noticing the name engraved a badge attached to the breastplate of the saddle.

Swiftwind let out a neigh of joy, enjoying the gentle scratches until Adora spoke again, "Listen, today is the biggest in my entire life, and the thing is… I need you not to get these three arrested…" Luckily, the blonde was undeterred by Swiftwind's snort of disagreement, "Just for twenty four hours! Then- you can chase each other your heart's content! Okay?"

Catra sighed, having gotten back to her feet with Entrapta's help and approached Swiftwind, holding out her hand, silently asking for a truce. At first, Swiftwind only glared at the brunette, only relenting when Adora muttered, "Plus it's- also my birthday. Just so you know." It took another moment before releasing a defeated blow, and offering their front hoof to Catra to shake, which the magicat reluctantly did.

Adora smiled at the two, before the sound of a bell ringing in the distance caught her attention. She slowly walked between the two, causing them to step away from each other, everyone watching and following as the blonde made her way through the trees to follow the sound.

⚔

"Wait! Does Swifty not talk?" Adora couldn't help but ask.

“No.”

“Awe, why not?” The blonde pouted.

“Because I am not imitating your horse. He’s more tolerable this way.” Catra replied, making everyone aside from Adora laugh. Instead, she just rolled her eyes, fighting to keep a smile off her face.

“Actually, I have a question too,” Bow raised his hand for a second, “Shouldn’t Adora have seen her ‘mother’ again by now?”

“Just changing things up, Arrows. You’ll see.”

“Fair enough.” Bow shrugged.

“Anyway, it didn’t take them long to clear the woods and stumble upon a bridge leading to the kingdom of Brightmoon…”

⚔

Adora gasped as she rushed onto the bridge leading into the village. Her eyes sparkled at the buildings and people around her,

taking in as much as she could as fast as she could.

"Wow…!" The breathtaking view made any thoughts of her mother or having to return to her tower disappearing to the back of her mind. Everywhere she looked there were kids running around, stalls of all kinds, and so many decorations that were all centered around what looked like a sun, "Everything is so beautiful..!"

"Glad you think so, princess. Just- maybe stick close to one of us, okay? It's easy to get lost in the crowd when the village gets this busy." Catra gently explained.

"Okay. Well, the lanterns don't happen until tonight. What should we do until then?"

"We can show you around!" Scorpia smiled.

"We can show you our favorite places to hide." Entrapta added, missing the deadpan stare Catra and Swiftwind gave her.

"Sounds great! I can't wait!"

The trio nodded, beginning to give Adora an impromptu tour of Brightmoon, taking care to hide whenever they or Swiftwind spotted any guards passing by. They spend half an hour walking around before Adora spotted a library, and her attention was completely diverted. Catra was happy to indulge her though, and

the two dipped inside while the the other two went with Swiftwind to find a place to watch the lanterns later as well as find something for lunch.

The girls quickly found themselves huddled together on the floor with a small stack of books in front of them. Catra found it endearing, yet a little sad at how excited Adora was at having sudden access to new books to read. Still, she found herself blushing every time Adora's interest was sparked. She had barely noticed the three hours they'd spent reading together pass until Scorpia and Entrapta peaked into the room.

"Hey, Wildcat. We rented a small boat to watch the lanterns tonight."

"Annnd, we found lunch!" Entrapta added, holding up a small pouch, small loaves of bread were sticking out of the top.

Smiling, Catra slowly got to her feet, "Ready to go eat then, princess?"

Adora nodded, also getting up. She quickly returned the books they had picked out to their proper shelves before hurrying to follow the trio outside, "Ooh, are we gonna have a picnic?"

"Yeah, basically. We found a nice spot near the docks." Scorpia replied with a bright smile.

“Okay! Sounds like a lot of… fun…” As they walked down the street, they passed by a large portrait of the royal family painted into the stone wall. The king and queen stood tall in the center, and a little girl that looked to be around three was in the king’s arms, hugging him. She had pink eyes, and pink hair that changed to purple on her under layers, and a bright smile to match her sparkling eyes. In the queen’s arms was a baby, who unlike the rest of the family had long blonde hair and bright blue eyes. She stared at it for a few minutes, overhearing a little girl telling her mother the flowers she set in front of it were for the lost princess.

“Adora?”

“Sorry!” She quickly scrambled to catch up to the others after forcing herself to tear her attention away from the portrait. She smiled, putting the image to the back of her mind as the group took a seat under a tree that overlooked the harbor. She carefully took a seat next to Catra, adjusting the skirt of her dress. She smiles, quietly thanking Entrapta when she handed her some bread a bottle of water.

The group ate in relative silence, just watching people walk about the harbor, either working or preparing for the lantern ceremony that evening. It was a relaxing sight for Adora, to simply witness everyday life happening around her. She knew it was a small thing, yet she couldn’t help but think about everything else she had been missing over the years, stuck to seeing the world from her small window for eighteen long years.

After everyone ate, they passed time by decorating Adora's braid with flowers Scorpia had found, and taking another quick stroll around the village before making their way to a secluded dock where a single rowboat was waiting when the sun started to set. Catra carefully stepped down into the boat and sat down, holding her hand out to Adora and carefully helping her step and sit down across from her, "Are you two coming?" Catra asked, glancing up at her friends.

"Nah, you two have fun. We'll be waiting here with Swiftwind!" Scorpia smiled, gently patting the alicorn who whinnied happily in response.

"Have fun!" Entrapta added, before her pigtails moved down and gently nudged the rowboat to start floating away from the dock.

"Thank you!" Adora called, slipping her satchel off her shoulder and setting it down behind her.

Entrapta and Scorpia waved, Catra briefly returning the gesture before gripping the oars and starting to steer the boat out towards a center point of the lake where she knew no other boats would be going.

Once they reached a secluded spot on the lake, and the sun had set, Adora started to feel her nerves building up. She was finally about to achieve her dream. She was going to see the lanterns up close, and not just her window! But… what then? What was she supposed to do once it was over? Go back to her tower? Wait for her mother to get home and let life go on like her adventure had

never happened? The thought of never seeing her new friends again, or having the freedom to explore the world again made her stomach twist. Now that she truly knew what she had been missing out on, she wasn't sure she would ever be able to go without it again. Her mother would surely notice her change in mood and then- what if she learned what she had done? She would be heartbroken!

No, she wouldn't be heartbroken. She would be furious .

"Is everything okay?"

The blonde flinched, looking up at Catra when her voice cut through her thoughts, "Huh? Oh! Sorry- yes! Yes, everything is fine. I'm just… I…" She sighed.

"You're..?"

"I'm terrified. I've been.. I've been staring at the lanterns out of my window for eighteen years, dreaming about what this moment might feel like." Adora quietly explained, staring at her reflection in the water, "What if.. What if it's not everything that I dreamed it would be?"

Catra offered a gentle smile, placing a hand on her shoulder, "It will be."

“And what if it is? What.. What do I do then?”

“Well, that’s good part I guess…” Catra gave her shoulder a light squeeze, “You get to go find a new dream.”

“A new dream…” Adora whispered the words, like she was trying them out. She finally looked away from the water to more properly face the brunette. She felt Catra’s hand slide down her arm, and she grasped her hand within her own before she could fully pull away from her, “Do you have a dream too?”

“I…” Catra’s ears folded back slightly, and Adora swore she could see a blush forming underneath the fur on her cheeks. Before she could come up with an answer though, the first of the floating lanterns rose from the Brightmoon palace, prompting the lighting of the thousands of others within the village to follow, before they too were released into the sky.

Gasping at the new site, Adora turned and tightly gripped the side of the rowboat, her pupils dilating as the lanterns started to ascend into the night sky, “Wow…” She looked around as the boats in the distance also started lighting lanterns and releasing them to join the rest above them, letting the gentle winds take them where they needed to go.

“Adora?”

Looking towards the magicat, she gasped when she was presented with two small lanterns Catra had just lit, offering one to her companion. Slowly reaching out, Adora grasped one of the them, a wide, yet warm smile forming as the two pushed the lanterns up and off to join the rest in the sky.

"I have something for you too." Adora spoke up after a moment of silence. Catra's ears perked up when Adora reached for her satchel. She had assumed the entire time it was to make carrying her frying pan easier, since the handle had been sticking out of it. Her eyes widened when instead the crown was pulled out of it, "I should have given this back to you sooner, but I was just scared. The thing is.. I'm not scared anymore. Know what I mean..?"

Catra took the crown and set it to the side, her blush deepening, "Yeah, I think I'm starting to."

The two kept eye contact, the romantic glow of the lanterns surrounding them and bouncing off of the lake. The distance between them was slowly starting to disappear, neither able to take their eyes off of the other.

Just as they were about to close the distance between them, something, or, someone caught Adora's attention. Her eyes widened when she realized who it was, and she pulled away, "Catra?"

"Huh? Yeah..? Is everything okay..?" Catra looked behind her at the distant shore, but nobody was there.

“Yeah! Yeah, I just… I saw my mother…”

Catra tensed, her hand pausing over the oar she’d reached for, “Are you sure that’s a good idea..?”

“I.. If she knows, I need to face her. Maybe once she sees I’m okay she’ll see I can handle myself and I won’t have to worry about going back to the tower!”

“I don’t…” The brunette caught the hopeful shimmer in Adora’s eyes and sighed. Nodding, she started rowing the boat towards the shore, worry gnawing at her gut the entire way.

⚔

Once Catra parked the boat, Adora carefully got to her feet, nodding gratefully to her when she took her hand and helped her step out, “I’ll be right back, I promise! Hopefully I can properly introduce you two!”

“Yeah… hopefully.” Catra smiled nervously, watching Adora disappear in the brush.

Adora felt herself tense when a chilly breeze swept around her, “Mother..?” She called out, yelping when Shadow Weaver seemed

to appear out of nowhere in front of her.

"Well! I thought you'd stay on that boat forever!"

"How did you find me…?" Adora couldn't help but tense when her mother wrapped her arms around her and pulled her into a hug.

"Oh, it was easy really. I just listened to the sound of complete and utter betrayal and followed that." Weaver sneered, eying the way her daughter's hair was braided with disapproval, removing one of the flowers near her ear and dropping it to the ground, "We're going home, Adora. Now." She glared, grabbing her wrist and turning to walk away, only to be met with resistance as Adora planted her feet.

"Mother wait!" Pulling her hand free, the teen stepped back, "You don't understand. I've been on such an incredible journey and I've seen and learned so much! I- I even met someone. I made friends!"

"Yes, the wanted thieves, I'm so proud. Come on Adora-"

"-Mother please! Can't you see? I'm fine! Better than fine, even! I'm handling myself just fine and with my hair braided like this I can protect it! Plus I… I think Catra likes me…" She added with a blush.

Halting in her tracks, Shadow Weaver turned to Adora, an eyebrow raised, “Likes you? Adora that is the most ridiculous thing I’ve ever heard! What on Etheria makes you say that?”

Suddenly feeling tense and now uncertain, Adora bit her lip, “She’s so kind and- and she brought me to see the lanterns! She even stayed after I gave her that crown thing back on the boat! She’s spent the entire trip showing me things and teaching me about Brightmoon!”

Shadow Weaver didn’t completely understand everything Adora was saying, but she heard enough to move things in the direction she wanted them to, “You just gave her back this crown? And what’s to stop her from running off with it now that you aren’t with her? People like her will wait for the opportunity, and you coming back to me just gave it to her.”

“What…?” Adora frowned, “No. No, she wouldn’t do that. She’s waiting for us now! I was actually hoping to introduce you two..”

“Adora I’m trying to stop you from getting hurt. I don’t want you going back there just to be disappointed. Let’s just go home before this nonsense goes any further.”

“Mother *please* , Catra isn’t like that. Come on, I’ll show you!” Adora pleaded, tugging on her mother’s arm.

Sighing, Shadow Weaver relented, “Fine, but when she’s gone you’re coming home.”

“Yeah yeah, okay!” Adora smiled, pulling her mother forward out of the brush back to the clearing, “Catra-!” She started, her excitement momentary until she took notice that the rowboat empty, and the crown gone, “Catra…?” She slowly released her mother’s arm, stepping forward towards the boat, looking around desperately for any sign of her friend, “Catra?!” Tears welled up in her eyes as the realization her mother’s words had been true stabbed her in the heart. Slowly, she turned around, seeing her mother looking down at her with pity, her arms open for the teen.

A small sob escaped as she lunged into her mother’s arms, clinging to her as her tears started to fall, “I- I don’t understand she- she was…”

“Shh, I know… I know…” Shadow Weaver wrapped an arm around the blonde, starting to lead her away from the boat and back towards the forest. This time, there was no resistance from her daughter.

⚔

“Noooo! What happened to you, mommy?!” Finn exclaimed.

“That would be spoilers, Finn.” Catra chuckled, ruffling their hair, “You’ll see soon enough.”

“Did you leaves auntie!?” Galaxy gasped.

“No, Gal, I would never.” Catra hummed, squeaking when Adora suddenly cupped her cheek.

“You better not.” Adora smirked, kissing her cheek before resting her head on her shoulder, managing to suppress a yawn.

Though she was blushing, Catra wrapped her free arm around Adora’s waist and held her and by extension, Finn close. The kit had curled up again, mostly in Adora’s lap but had shifted slightly so they could lay their lead on Catra’s chest. The twins were clearly the ones struggling to stay awake at this point to hear the rest of the story. They had curled up together next to Catra, but were actually laying down now.

“Am I free to continue?” The brunette chuckled, smiling when Finn started to purr and quickly nodded.

⚔

When Catra and Adora never returned once the lanterns had all but floated away, Scorpia and Entrapta began to get nervous.

“Do you think they’re alright..?” Scorpia asked, glancing towards Entrapta, who had been idly petting Swiftwind.

“Maybe they just went for a walk after? Or maybe… oh no…” Entrapta noticed a palace boat docking in the harbor, “Scorpia…”

“What’s wrong?” Scorpia followed Entrapta’s gaze, her own eyes widening when she saw guards unloading Catra, who was in cuffs, while another guard walked behind them carrying the crown. Catra was clearly struggling, yelling something about an old woman about Adora being in trouble. The two shared a look. Both wanted to help but were wanted themselves, “What should we do?”

“Catra had to be talking about Adora’s ‘mother’ right?”

Scorpia furrowed her eyebrows, “Why did you say it like that?”

“Seriously…?” Entrapta deadpanned, “It took me a few hours to realize who Adora was.”

“I… don’t follow.”

Sighing, Entrapta ran her hand through her bangs, “Adora has been in that tower for her entire life, held by an old woman who claims to be her mother who also desperately wants to hide the

fact her hair has healing magical properties. We've both seen the portrait in town, Adora looks exactly like the missing princess…"

Scorpia stared at her friend for a moment before it all processed and fell into place, "Oh.. Oh! So- what do we do then? We can't report it to the guards because we'll get arrested! But we can't save Adora without Catra because who knows how long the guards will take before they… you know."

"We need to break Catra out of jail first obviously." Entrapta looked to Swiftwind, "Think you might be able to help us, Swiftwind?" With a whinny, Swiftwind nodded, making Entrapta smile, "Great! We don't have a lot of time, so we need to plan fast!"

⚔

Catra paced back and forth in her small cell, her ears pinned. She knew what was coming, but saving Adora was more important. She'd tried to explain everything to the guards, but they didn't believe a word she said.

She felt stupid for not figuring it out sooner. Of course Adora was the missing princess. It all made total sense. She couldn't let Adora be dragged back to be locked away in that tower for the rest of her life. She gasped when the door to her cell suddenly opened and the captain of the guard stepped into the cell.

“Catra?”

“Yes…?” She felt herself go numb as she realized what was probably coming.

“Do you… do you really know where the lost princess is?”

That wasn’t what she had expected to hear. Her ears perked up in surprise as she slowly nodded, “Yes. At least, I think so. She looks just like the portrait in town and she’s the right age and-”

“Right right. So, do you know where she is?”

“The woman that has her probably got her back the tower she’s kept her in by now. I know where that is though, yeah.”

The captain nodded slowly, taking a deep breath, “If you’re telling the truth, I can maybe see about lightening your punishment-”

“I don’t care about that, Arrows. I just want her to be safe away from that crazy woman. I’m guessing you’ve actually met her yourself. She was probably the one who told you were to find me last night.”

“I…” Bow’s eyes widened as the realization hit him, “Okay, come on then. Take me to this tower.”

Nodding, Catra slowly followed Bow out of the cell, and the two raced down the hallway. Once they reached the exit, they opened the door, jumping back when they opened it to Swiftwind rearing up ready to kick the door down.

"Whoa! Swifty! Down!" Bow exclaimed, nudging Catra behind him.

Swiftwind neighed, backing up, glaring at Bow when he realized Catra was with him.

"Sorry! We were just trying to break in and save our friend!" Entrapta exclaimed, before pausing when she realized Catra was-fine? She wasn't even cuffed anymore, "Oh. I see maybe we are a little late."

"Just a bit." Catra rolled her eyes, smiling fondly as she crossed her arms, "We're going back to the tower to get Adora out of there before that crazy witch hides her elsewhere. Coming?"

"Absolutely, Wildcat!" Scorpia smiled.

⚔

Adora had been staring at the floor for nearly an hour, sitting in complete silence as her mother took all of the flowers out of her hair and undid the braids, "There. It never happened!" Shadow

Weaver hummed as she got to her feet, picking up the basket that held all of the flowers. She slowly made her way to the doorway that left Adora's room, "Now wash up for dinner." She paused when Adora still didn't respond. She sighed, "I really did try, Adora. I tried to warn you about what was out there. The world is dark, and selfish, and cruel. If it finds even the slightest rays of sunshine. It destroys it." She huffed, yanking the curtains closed behind her as she went downstairs.

With a sigh, Adora slowly laid back on her bed, staring at the various paintings that she'd done over the years. The longer she stared though, the more she noticed the similarities that were scattered throughout each of her drawings. She squinted, slowly pushing herself to a sitting position as she continued to stare at her works. Whether it was between different artworks or whether it was somehow implemented into a drawing, there was always the same sun symbol that she'd seen in the decorations in town, "What…?" She whispered, getting to her feet as she kept looking around. Everywhere she looked, all she could see was that sun. Why was it everywhere? She gasped when her mind was suddenly filled with images, almost like a vision.

She could see a baby mobile with that same sun decal staring down at her, and the blurry faces of parents and a young girl staring at her. Then those faces were completed as she thought of the portrait she'd seen in town, and the baby the parents had been holding. No, not just parents, the king and queen . And the baby… her eyes widened when she remembered the crown when she'd first met Catra, and when she had put the crown on her head…

Gasping for breath, Adora stumbled, falling backwards against her vanity and knocking the stool in front of it over. Everything had

fallen into place; everything made sense! She was the lost princess! Mother wasn't her mother! She was- she had taken her from her real family to do the very thing she warned her that the world would do if it knew she had powers!

"Adora?" She looked up, glaring towards the curtains that covered her doorway when she heard her 'mother' calling out to her, "Adora, what's going on up there?" Straightening her posture, Adora walked out of the room, gripping the curtains as she finally met her 'mother's' gaze as she started up the stairs, "Are you alright?"

"I'm the lost princess…" Adora breathed.

Shadow Weaver scoffed, "Speak up, Adora. You know how I feel when you mumble like that-"

"I am the lost princess! Aren't I?!" Adora snapped, glaring openly at Shadow Weaver, "Did I mumble, 'mother'? Or should I even call you that?"

Shadow Weaver stared, eyes wide in stunned silence for a few minutes before attempting to laugh it off, "What? Do you even *hear* yourself? Adora, why would you ask such a ridiculous question?" She tried to approach and hug the blonde, only for her to shove her away with a scoff.

“It was you! It was all *you !*” Adora yelled, storming off down the staircase to the main room of the tower.

“Everything I did was to protect you, Adora-”

“-No! Everything you did was for your benefit! You wanted my hair and my powers! This entire time you’ve been doing exactly what you said everyone else would do! All this time I’ve been hiding from the world, when I should have been hiding from *you !*” She spat, watching closely as the older woman descended the stairs to approach her.

“Where is it you think you’ll go? She won’t be there for you!”

Adora narrowed her eyes, realizing that Shadow Weaver had to be behind Catra’s disappearance as well, “What did you do to her..?”

“I made sure the guards found that criminal. She is going to prison, where she will be taken care of.”

Eyes widening, Adora looked away, “No…”

“Now now, it’s alright, listen to me. Everything is as it should be…” Weaver tried, reaching out towards the blonde, only for her to grab her wrist and glare at her again.

“No! You were wrong about the world, and you were wrong, about me! And I will *never* let you use my hair again!”

Groaning, Shadow Weaver yanked her wrist free, stumbling back and knocking over the standing mirror in the room, shattering it and sending the pieces across the floor.

“Adora… you need to listen to me right now-”

“No!” Adora glared, putting some distance between them as she backed towards the window, “I’m not staying here with you anymore. I don’t care what I have to do, I’ll make my own way!” She grabbing the shutters and pulled them open.

“I don’t think so!” Weaver glared, lunging forward and grabbing Adora’s arm, making her yelp.

“Let me go!”

“Adora!?”

The two froze, glancing towards the window as Catra’s voice carried up into the tower from the ground below.

“Impossible…”

Adora smirked, trying to turn back towards the window, only for Weaver to yank her back and send her to the floor, “You can’t keep me here forever.” She seethed, perking up once she heard Catra starting to scale the side of the tower. She quickly got to her feet before Shadow Weaver could corner her. She backed up slowly, “I meant what I said. I’m never going to let you use my hair again. It doesn’t matter if you keep my trapped. I won’t give you what you want.”

“Adora!?”

The two looked back as Catra all but tumbled over the window sill, quickly scrambling to her feet. Her eyes widened when she realized what was going on, “Catra! You’re alright!”

“Of course I’m fine. What’s-” Catra gasped when Shadow Weaver grabbed her and shoved her against the window sill, like she was preparing to push her out.

“No!” Adora gasped, freezing in place, “Please- don’t!”

“Then I suggest you do as I say.” Shadow Weaver seethed.

Noticing a knife sitting on the counter, Adora glared, grabbing it in one hand and her hair in the other, “Let her go. Now!”

Tensing and freezing up, Weaver stared at Adora.

"Look, I'll- I'll stay with you, okay? Things- things can go back to how they used to be." Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes at that, "I won't run, I won't try to escape. Just- let her go, don't hurt her."

"Adora… don't.." Catra whispered, wincing when Weaver's grip on her tightened.

"But, if you hurt her, do anything to her, I'm cutting my hair." She emphasized her point by holding the blade up to her hair.

"No- don't!" Weaver gasped, releasing Catra and stepping towards Adora. Catra immediately stepped towards the stairs away from the window.

Once Adora was sure she was safe, she smirked as she took the blade and sliced through her hair.

"NO!"

Dropping the blade and her hair, Adora backed away as she watched Shadow Weaver rush forward and grabbed at the hair off the floor as the platinum blonde quickly faded away to a more natural blonde. The second the witch touched it, all of the magic faded as well, rapidly aging the woman many years. She cried

out, scrambling to somehow shield herself from view as she frantically backed towards the window.

Adora gasped, reaching out as Weaver tripped over the window sill and plummeted towards the ground.

The girls stood in stunned silence for a few minutes, though Catra was unable to hold back a laugh when she faintly heard Entrapta asking whose cape just fell from the sky.

Slowly, Adora walked over to the shattered mirror, looking at herself and her now much shorter hair.

"You know, you look really good with a pixie cut." Catra smiled, gently running her fingers through the blonde hair.

"Thanks…" Adora blushed, turning towards her, "I'm glad you're alright… she said she turned you into the guards…"

"She did, but the captain of the guard listened to me when I said I knew who you were and where you were. He's waiting outside with Entrapta and Scorpia, waiting to take you home to your family."

Nodding, Adora looked around, "I guess we should get going then. Come on, we had to come in a different way when she brought me back." She explained as she grabbed one of the tiles

in the floor, moving it to reveal a latter that led down to a staircase.

Catra's ears perked up, and she smiled, nodding, following Adora as they descended the tower one last time.

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Galaxy and Estelle were fast asleep, curling up in their beds once Glimmer and Bow moved them to their respective bunk.

Adora was cradling a mostly asleep Finn as Catra finished up the story, a steady purr coming from both magicats.

"Once Adora was reunited with her family, the kingdom was overjoyed, for their lost princess had finally returned, and she was given the family and the happy ending that she more than deserved."

Adora smiled, blushing when Catra leaned down and kissed her cheek.

Slowly, the two stood up, each kissing Finn on the top of the head before Adora gently laid them down in their bed, tucking them in. Glimmer quietly gathered the teacups and sippy cups before the four finally slipped out of the room and closed the door.

“Perfect timing. I am exhausted.” Glimmer chuckled quietly.

“Glad I could tire you out, Sparkles.” Catra snorted, “See you guys tomorrow?”

“Yup! Don’t forget about our meeting with Salineas tomorrow.”

“Yeah yeah, I remember.” Catra sighed, waving at the king and queen before following Adora down the hallway to their bedroom for the night.

“That was a sweet story, Catra.” Adora smiled, grasping her wife’s hand as they cuddled up in their bed together.

“Well I do have a base to go off of, I just find it fun to change up the characters with our friends to make it more interesting for the kids.”

“One day you should tell a story you can include them in too!”

“Ha, yeah I should. I’ll have to do some digging in the library.” Catra hummed, pulling the blanket over them, careful not to disturb Melog, who was sleeping peacefully at the end of the bed.

Nodding, Adora closed her eyes, yawning a final time as she drifted off to sleep. Catra was quick to follow after she kissed her wife on the forehead a final time, “Good night, my princess…”

End Notes

Ahhh I cannot believe after literally 2 years I'm finally posting this. I have two others that I've started, but this is the one I've been committed to the most to kick the series off. This is definitely one that I won't post on super often just because they're (clearly) long oneshots that take me a while to write and edit, but I'm so very happy with how this came out!

I really hope you enjoyed it and I can't wait to hear what you all think about it!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!